

6-3-5 Brainwriting

6 people · 3 ideas · 5 rounds — silent parallel ideation

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

6-3-5 Brainwriting is a structured silent-ideation method: **six** participants each write **three** ideas on a sheet, then pass it on; over **five** rounds each sheet accumulates and builds on prior ideas. In theory it yields up to 108 ideas in about 30 minutes, free of the loudest-voice bias of spoken brainstorming.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Devised by German marketing professor Bernd Rohrbach, who published it as 'Methode 635' in 1968.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Verbal brainstorming suffers from production blocking, evaluation apprehension and dominance by extroverts. Writing in parallel removes these, so quieter and more original contributions survive.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

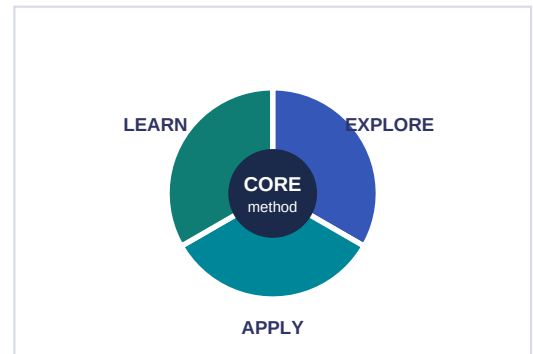


Figure 1. 6-3-5 Brainwriting framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

HOW IT IS USED

Each round, participants add three ideas, reading and building on what previous people wrote, then pass the sheet. After five passes the sheets are collected, clustered and voted on.

WHEN IT IS USED

Early ideation, especially with mixed-seniority or mixed-personality groups where spoken brainstorming would be skewed.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Facilitators, product and innovation teams, and educators teaching group ideation.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

Compared with Osborn's spoken brainstorming, brainwriting **equalises participation** and builds on ideas cumulatively, tackling the well-documented weaknesses of the group brainstorm.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Brainstorming *Slibrary 7*

Dot Voting *Slibrary 2*

2x2 Matrix *Slibrary 7*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Rohrbach, B. (1969) 'Kreativ nach Regeln – Methode 635', *Absatzwirtschaft*, 12, pp. 73–75.

Paulus, P.B. and Nijstad, B.A. (eds.) (2003) *Group Creativity*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.